

Host DADA



Hi everyone.

First of all, thank you so much for being my guest today.

I graduated from Sungkyunkwan University right here
and while I was a student, I was part of the Yusaeng Culture.

The university time to time asked me to lead tours of Sungkyunkwan for young visitors,
so I've been doing this for a while.

These days I work as a marketer and content creator.

My name is Lee Dawon — you can just call me Dada.

Could I ask you to introduce yourselves?



Super, thank you.

So — what made you sign up for this experience?

I'm guessing you haven't heard much about Sungkyunkwan, at least not like Gyeongbokgung Palace, right?

But actually, you're probably more familiar with it than you think.

I'm sure you've seen some Korean banknotes.



1,000-won bill. This man is Yi I, and he was a student at Sungkyunkwan.

On the 5,000-won bill, Yi Hwang — he was a professor here.

On the 10,000-won bill, King Sejong — widely considered the greatest king in Korean history — he was essentially the chairman of the board.

And on the 50,000-won bill, Shin Saimdang — Yi I's mother, Il. So a Sungkyunkwan parent.

And 1,000-won bill? That's the main lecture hall of Sungkyunkwan, right here.

So as you can see, Sungkyunkwan holds a deeply important place in Korean history and culture.



Let me give you a quick overview before we start walking.

Founded in 1398, Sungkyunkwan served as the nation's highest educational institution for the entire 500 years of the Joseon Dynasty.

It was also the headquarters of Confucianism — the state ideology — and home to Munmyo, the shrine where Confucius was honored.

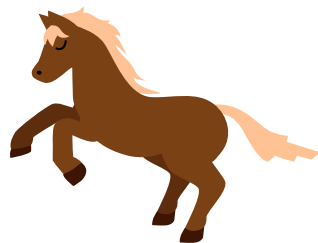
The students who studied here were called "Yusaeng."

They were full-scholarship students — around 100 to 200 at a time — and they also performed the ritual ceremonies of the state.

So think of this place as both a sacred ritual ground and a campus.

Now, take a look at this stone marker.

It say "dismount your horse here."



Horses were incredibly expensive back then too — it was just like an Audi or a Lamborghini.

So this is saying: no matter who you are enter with humility and reverence.

I think that's a nice mindset for us too, as we step into 600 years of history place.

Shall we go in? Follow me

Even the crown prince enrolled here as a student.

And since the institution oversaw the nation's most sacred rituals, the king himself would visit.

See over there? That was the king's palanquin drop-off — basically, the king's parking lot.

And this gate right here — you'll notice it's closed.

That's because it was the king's gate.

Class system not anymore here Korea, but even today? Sorry, Mm-mm.



Let me test whether you were paying attention.

What were the two purposes of Sungkyunkwan? Education and ritual. Exactly — thank you.

Those two functions were actually separated into different zones, and we're going to visit the ritual side first — Daeseongjeon.

Daeseongjeon for ancestral rites.

So who were they honoring?

Confucius — the most important figure in Confucianism — and great.

There's a cute story about this.

One of my professors — Professor Kim Yong-gwan, who taught microeconomics — he was already a very elderly gentleman at that time.

He told us that here, this hall enshrines two of his own ancestors.

So every morning on way to work, he'd say "Good morning, papa," and every evening, "Bye, papa."

What an adorable old man.



Now, you're probably curious about the relationship between Sungkyunkwan and Sungkyunkwan University.

The university is the direct successor of Sungkyunkwan.



Here's a question — whose birthday is Christmas?

Right, Birthday of Jesus and it's celebrated worldwide.

Well, Sungkyunkwan University is the only university in the world that gets a day off on Confucius's birthday.

Also, spring and fall, they hold a grand ceremony called Seokjeon Daerye right here.

It features Munmyo Jeryeak, a style of ritual music that exists only here in Korea.

They even use ancient instruments lost in China and Japan.

Furthermore, the ceremony was actually lost in China itself during the Cultural Revolution so Chinese scholars had to come here to study and reconstruct it.

That gate over there only opens when those ceremonies are held.

But doesn't it look like it's even better than the king's gate?

And path right there — looks like a lovely place for stroll, doesn't it?

But this path and gate are reserved. For the spirits — the souls enshrined inside.
So not for the living.

I should warn you — I've actually seen elderly Confucian scholars scold people who accidentally walk on this path.

They absolutely didn't know why old man was scolding them.
So be careful.



Now we're heading to the examination grounds.

But first, let me tell you about how admissions and graduation worked here. You couldn't just walk in here— you had to prove yourself first. Specifically, you had to pass the exams to become a "Saengwon" or "Jinsa. They only selected 100 of each, once every three years. Not easy to get in, right?

But here's the thing — Sungkyunkwan wasn't just any school. It was a training ground for the nation's elite government officials. So there was no graduation requirement. Why? Because you stayed until you passed. Only by passing the national civil service examination — the Gwageo.

So picture this campus — do you imagine full of fresh-faced young students? Surprisingly, the average age of incoming students was 33. The average student's age was 45 — honestly, closer to professor age. There were even students in 70s. And the average time here? was 11 years. Some of them might closer to meeting their ancestor papa than to graduating.



That Gwageo exam — was held right here, at Bicheondang.

Take a look around.

During one exam, eight people were actually crushed to death.

Can you imagine how packed it must have been?

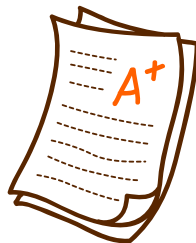
During the reign of King Jeongjo, the number of examinees reached 111,838.

But here's a fun detail — the number of answer sheets was only 38,614.

So what happened to the rest?

I think we all had classmates who showed up just to fill a seat.

I'm guessing it was something like that.

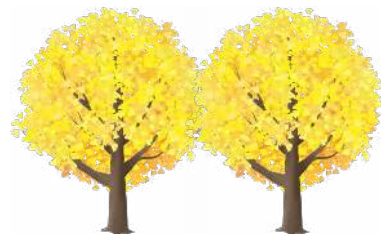


We've seen the examination grounds, and now we've arrived at the educational quarter.

And the first thing that catches your eye
— those two magnificent 500-year-old ginkgo trees.
These trees come with some stories.

Long ago, King Sejong — the great king on the 10,000-won bill, remember? — had a dream that a great dragon was coiled around this ginkgo tree and rose up into the sky. He was so startled that he immediately sent a servant to check on the tree. And the servant found just one scholar studying here.

Why here? Who knows.
But that scholar passed the exam with the highest score.
After that, students would fight to sit next to this tree.
We all had classmates like that, right?



There's another story.

These ginkgo trees are beautiful, but if you've ever smelled the fruit of a ginkgo tree — absolutely terrible.

Back in the day, there were students who didn't feel like studying. They actually declared a study strike because of the ginkgo fruit's smell. So the authorities held a ritual ceremony —directly to the trees.

"Dear ginkgo trees, we humbly ask that you stop bearing fruit."

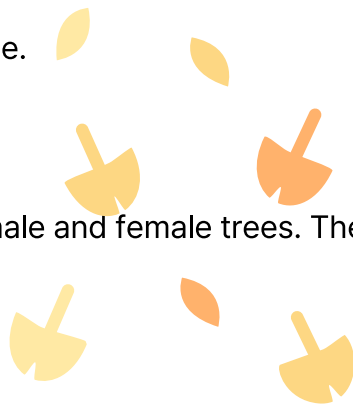
And sure enough, these two trees have never produced fruit since.
So what happened?

Did ancient Korean shamanism actually work?

Well — ginkgo trees are dioecious, meaning there are separate male and female trees. These two are same sex.

So reproduction was never an option.

Science beats shamanism.



And this beautiful building facing the ginkgo trees —
this is Myeongnyundang, the main lecture hall. The very building printed on 1,000-won bill.

There's something you can't see from out here —
inside, there's a calligraphy, written by 77th-generation descendant of Confucius.
Imagine having Confucius or Jesus as your 77th grandfather.
That must be quite something.

Government-appointed instructors were sent to educate the scholars.
But the system was nothing like what we'd expect.
There were no fixed classes, no curriculum set, no lectures to attend.
Students were expected to study on their own and would approach the instructors only when
they needed to discuss ideas or report on their progress.

Essentially, it was self-directed learning.
And we all know how hard it is, right?
I think this might be one of the reasons they stayed here over ten years.



So what on earth did these students actually do all day if there were no classes?
During the daytime, they often didn't even stay on campus — many spent their days at the homes of "Banchon," I'll tell you about later.
Others went out to meet friends.
Most of them just... lived freely, with no particular schedule.

Wait — so was Sungkyunkwan basically like a free-range farm?
Not exactly.
There were rules, and the most important one was attendance.

But Dada, didn't you just say there were no classes?
The attendance wasn't for classes — it was for the dining hall.

Do you know how Koreans greet each other?
We say "Annyeonghaseyo."
But between close friends, we say "Have you eaten?"
Asking whether someone has had a meal — that's our hello.
Food has always been serious business in Korea.



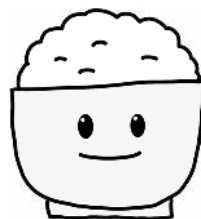
Sungkyunkwan students had to sign in at the dining hall twice a day — morning and evening — to earn one attendance point. You needed to accumulate a certain number of these points just to qualify for the exam.

The system was designed to keep students dedicated to their studies.

Isn't it funny that the way they measured academic commitment wasn't through classes or score — it was through eating.

You could be on campus all day, but if you skipped the dining hall, it didn't count.

The most important part of your daily routine?
Going to the cafeteria and eating your meal.



And this is that very important dining hall.

What was on the menu? The menu is what really matters, right?

Every meal — breakfast and dinner, all free — included rice, soup, fermented soybean paste, kimchi, seasoned vegetables, salted seafood, dried fish, and fresh greens.

Sounds like a vegan menu.

Fish and meat? They were served as a special treat four times every ten days.

So was the food any good?

We can't know for sure, but there are historical records of students complaining about it.

I mean that's cafeteria food, right?

But for poor scholars, this free meal was an incredible financial support for sure.

One more, everyone here enjoy a drink?

Sungkyunkwan University has a strict no-alcohol policy on campus.

Old Sungkyunkwan no private alcohol rule too.

But twice a month, they delivered alcohol to each room.

Do you wanna enroll here?

I'm honestly not sure if that was necessary.



Now we've covered meals — but there's something else that's just as important.

What could it be?

The dormitory. This building.

How many people do you think shared one of these rooms? Take a guess.

Two students per room, twenty rooms total.

And here's a surprising fact — SKKU students were using these as dormitories until 2005. 2005! That's practically modern.

I wasn't at the university yet back then — so I only heard about it like a legend.

It's real though — they were eventually moved out for cultural heritage preservation.

Back again, — twenty rooms, two students each.

That's 40.

But how many scholars here did we say? 100 to 200.

So where was everyone? Camping?



This is where the "Banchon" village and the "Banin" people story begins.

Let's be honest, Sungkyunkwan doesn't look like a comfortable place to live, does it? These were sons of aristocratic families — the kind of people with a Porsche. And since all they really needed to do was show up at the dining hall, naturally, boarding houses sprang up nearby.

Also, someone also had to run this place, right?

The staff of Sungkyunkwan were government slaves — they were called "Banin." The village where they lived was called "Banchon."

But Banchon wasn't just any neighborhood.

It operated under something close to extraterritorial law — if you weren't a Banin, you were forbidden from living there.

It was an isolated, self-contained world, completely cut off from the rest of the city. You could compare it to the ghettos of medieval Europe.



Here's how one historical record describes them:

"Their spirit is so high that they regard death as casually as going home. When they fight, they sometimes slash their own chests and stab their own legs with knives" — a most peculiar custom indeed.

One thing's for sure — these were some wild people.

The Banin had three main roles.

First, running the daily operations of Sungkyunkwan.

Second, slaughtering and supplying meat.

And third, being boarding house hosts.



Now, despite the gap in social status, the relationship wasn't one of master and servant.

It was more like a patron and guardian.

Some of these bonds lasted a lifetime.

A Banin would sometimes grab a knife and fight anyone who insulted their scholar.

Wild people, huh?

That loyalty partly came from years of living together, but there was also an economic logic — when a scholar eventually rose to a government position,

he would repay his landlord generously.

There's one story that gives you a glimpse into this dynamic.

A scholar was boarding at a Banin household.

One day, he found no one, but only the landlord's wife at home — and, well, he made advances.

Just then the husband walked in, and the scholar quickly hid the wife and waved his hands. The husband said "Ah, of course, sir" and stepped out.

That was that.

Now, this scholar may have been messy, but he was apparently also brilliant — he eventually became a high-ranking official.

Remembering the debt he owed, he sent an enormous fortune to that household.

The husband, puzzled, asked his wife.

"This much? Why?"

She said, "Remember when the magistrate had a little fun in our room?"

"I do remember."

"That was me."

The husband replied, "If I had known it was you, I would've walked out every single time!"



It's just one anecdote, but it tells you about how the relationship between scholars and Banin was.

The Banin were slaves.

But these were the people who worked at the very heart of the highest education institution.

The lowest members of society, living with the future elite — that's the irony.

And because of the nature of their work,
they were experts of Sungkyunkwan's strict rules, rituals, and institutional systems.
Their economic power grew steadily.

On paper, they were government slaves — but in reality, no one could ignore them.

And perhaps most remarkably, through their constant interaction with scholars, many Banin developed genuine intellectual sophistication.

There are records of Banin who wrote poetry and published a book
— something unprecedented in all of Joseon history.



Sungkyunkwan as the center of Confucianism,
it was also deeply tied to a reverence for Chinese civilization.

Did you know that Hangul — the Korean alphabet, one of Korea's greatest treasures —
faced enormous opposition when King Sejong first created it?

Before Hangul, literacy meant knowing Chinese characters, and education was a privilege
for the very few.

That's exactly what makes the intellectual relationship between Sungkyunkwan's scholars
and its slaves so remarkable.

We'll wrap up our tour here — and for our next chapter,
we're going to learn how to read that very alphabet, Hangul, in just a few minutes.

Thank you so much for listening so well.



Host DADA



Hangul

Hangul is the writing system for the Korean language.

It was created by King Sejong the Great of the Joseon Dynasty and officially published in 1446.

It consists of just 24 letters, made up of remarkably simple lines, dots, and circles.

And the shapes are actually modeled after human speech organs.

For example, ㄱ depicts the root of the tongue blocking the upper palate.

And you'll be surprised when you see just how easy this writing system is.

Let's jump right in.

First, let me tell you a little story.

ㄱ — what does it look like? It's a gun.

Now look at ㅋ — the gun has been fired. It killed someone.

ㅌ — now they're locked up in prison.

So for ㄱ, just remember the "g" sound from "gun."

For ㅋ, remember the "k" sound from "kill."

And for ㅌ, remember the "p" sound from "prison."



Now let's learn a vowel. ㅣ — it looks like a tree, right?

It makes the "ee" sound, like in "tree."

Okay, now try reading this: 기피.

How do I? No, no — you can read it.

That's right! It's "gi-pi." It means "avoid."

Makes sense — if someone's carrying a gun, you'd want to avoid them, right?

Not so bad, is it? Let's learn a few more.

Now we're going to look at letters that resemble parts of the human body.

ㄣ — doesn't it look like a nose? Remember the "n" sound from "nose."

□ — what does this one look like? Think about body parts. It's a mouth.

In fact, it's also the Chinese character that means "mouth." Remember the "m"

And ㄨ — doesn't this look like a person stretching their arms out wide and proud?

It's the pose of a champion. Remember "ch."



Now let's learn some vowels. Vowels look a bit more abstract.

ㄚ — remember the tree from earlier? This one is to the right of it, as in "after." Remember the "a" from "after."

ㄛ — what about this one? It's not "after" — it's a bit more "earlier." Remember the "eo" sound from "earlier."

ㄜ — this looks like a base, right? Try this: say "base," but stretch out the sound — "baaaaa-eu-ssss." Hear that "eu" ? That's the sound. We'll remember it as "eu" from "base."

ㄝ — here, something is going over the baseline. Remember the "o" from "over."

ㄞ — and this one is under the baseline. Watch your foot — it's the "oo" sound from "foot."

Let's do a quick review.

"N" from "nose," "m" from "mouth," "ch" from "champion." Now the vowels: "ee" from "tree," "a" from "after," it comes before so "eo" from "earlier," "eu" from "base," "o" from "over," and watch out — "oo" from "foot."

Great job, everyone.

Aren't you curious?

Let's see if you can read something.

너무 차

너무 차 — perfect!

By the way, 너무 means "too much" in Korean, and 차 means "cold."

You did an amazing job.

You've already learned half of Hangul.

Surprising, right?

Shall we keep going? Are you having fun? Great.



ㄷ — this one looks like a room with an opening, right? What's open? It's a door. Remember the "d" from "door."

Oh, but wait — A trap just popped out of that open room! ㅇ — Remember the "t"

ㅈ — this is a basket. Remember the "b" from "basket."

ㅅ — this looks really sharp spike, doesn't it? Remember the "s" from "spike."

ㅊ — it kind of looks like a chair or a table, right? The middle part is connected with a joint. Remember the "j" from "joint."

ㄹ — this is a long, winding line. Remember the "l" from "line."

ㅎ — there's a flag sitting over a hole. It must be a golf hole. Remember the "h" from "hole."

Shall we learn just one more vowel?

ㅏ — doesn't it look like a ladder? It makes the "ae" sound, like in "ladder."

One more thing — you might come across this letter: ㅑ.

Native Korean speakers pronounce ㅑ and ㅏ slightly differently, but honestly, to your ears they'll sound pretty much the same. So just think of ㅑ as a slightly wonky ladder. Same sound, same "ae."

Wow, we've learned a lot. Let's review.

The door is open — "d" from "door."

Whoa, something popped out — "t" from "trap."

"B" from "basket."

Spike, "S" from "spike."

Joint squeezed tight in the middle — "j" from "joint."

A really long "l" from "line."

Hole in one! "H" from "hole."

And finally, "ae" from "ladder." Fantastic.

You've now learned almost all of Hangul — just one letter left.

Can you believe it? Shall we try reading something?

개 What is it? That's a dog. You just read "개" Amazing job.

크다. it's big. 개 크다. The dog is big. Ha — you see?

Now, this one is a character that foreigners love. They say it looks like a cat sitting down. Can you see it? But now, you don't just see a cat — you can actually read it as Hangul. That's right, it's "bim."

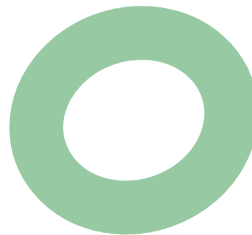
I'm so proud of you all.

개

크다

빔

You've probably heard that zero was one of the last numbers to be invented, right?
We're going to learn one last letter that's a little tricky.
But it's not that hard, so don't worry too much.
And look — it even looks like a zero.



ㅇ is "nothing." zero means nothing.
What do I mean by that?
When it comes at the beginning of a syllable, it makes no sound.
Seriously. Trust me.

But here's the twist — this same letter, when it comes at the end, sounds just like the end of "nothing" — it makes an "ng" sound.

So one letter, two jobs: silent at the start, "ng" at the end. Let me show you both.

아 — the ㅇ is nothing, so how do you read it? "Ah." That's right. Ah? Ah!
Now how about this? 가 and 강. Exactly. That's what ㅇ does.

Everyone, you've officially learned all of Hangul. That's it. Go home now.

Wait, don't leave yet. Want to take a look at this?

I know. Just give it a try. Read it.

This was the "d" from "door," right? And there are two of them. So? tense and sharp.

When you double any consonant, it becomes a tenser, stronger. ㄷ ㄸ ㅌ ㅍ

또 — this means "again" in Korean. You just say "ddo." That's right. one more?

비, right? How about this? 비싸 — perfect. This means "too expensive"



Shall we practice "nothing" one more time? 응 — this means "yeah."

Then what about this? Another thing I didn't teach you. Sorry I really didn't teach this one.

But it's not hard. When a vowel gets an extra stroke, you just add a "y" sound.

This was the "a" from "after," right? Add a "y" and it becomes "ya." Exactly.

Now try stretching out ㅏ — "yaaaaa." Hear how it ends in "ah"?

That's exactly why ㅑ is just ㅏ with one extra stroke. How scientific!



In Korean, it's what you say when you call out to someone, like "hey."

Let's try this one too. Oh, weird. You're right, it is.

This is the "o" from "over," and this is the "a" from "after." O and A. Shall we combine them?

Ohhh-ahh. "Wa." That's right — "wa."

What if we do this? 왓? "What?"

Korean works by assembling letters into blocks, like building blocks. Fun, right?

To explain a bit further — Hangul works like LEGO. A block.

Each syllable block has a spot for an initial consonant, a vowel in the middle, and a final consonant. The final consonant is optional — it can be there or not.

The Hangul currently 28 consonants, which can be combined to produce 11,172 syllables.

Everyone, I've taught you everything.

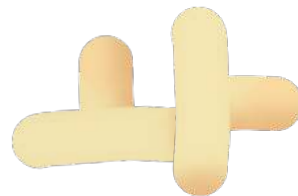
Let's try reading through the alphabet and then read some real Hangul around you.

You'll be able to read it.

Just use the "a" vowel sound. 가, 나, 다, 라 — like that.

Wow, you've even memorized it all. That's incredible.

Shall we go walk around and try reading things for real?



Did you have a good time today? I'd love to hear from each of you — what was your takeaway from today?

Thank you for sharing. I had a truly special and wonderful time too.

I'll also send the video of today's experience. Dont forget to message your email adress.

And if I may ask one small favor — if you enjoyed today,
I'd really appreciate it if you could leave a vivid, heartfelt review.
That's how I pay my rent, so —!

Everyone, do you remember the Gwageo?

The ultimate boss-level exam that every Yusaeng was working toward?

When a scholar passed, the king would bestow flowers upon them.

Well, since you all completed your Hangul studies today, instead of that, I've prepared Korean traditional candy necklace.

I hope the rest of your time in Korea is filled with happiness and joy.
Thank you so much.

